



CLERGY MEMBERS hold images of Eaton fire victims at an Altadena event marking the fire's anniversary. CARLIN STIEHL For The Times

TEHRAN WARNS TRUMP AGAINST STRIKES

Iran says it would target U.S. and Israel if they use force in support of protesters.

By JON GAMBRELL

DUBAI — A crackdown on nationwide protests in Iran has killed at least 538 people and even more are feared dead, activists said Sunday, while Tehran warned that the U.S. military and Israel would be “legitimate targets” if America uses force to protect demonstrators.

More than 10,600 people have been detained over the two weeks of protests, said the U.S.-based Human Rights Activists News Agency, which has been accurate in such counts in previous rounds of Iranian unrest in recent years. It relies on supporters in Iran crosschecking information. It said of those killed, 490 were protesters and 48 were members of security forces.

With the internet down in Iran and phone lines cut off, gauging the demonstrations from abroad has grown more difficult. The Associated Press has been unable to independently assess the toll, and the Iranian government has not offered overall casualty figures.

Observers abroad fear that the information blackout is emboldening hardliners within Iran’s security services to launch a bloody crackdown. Demonstrators flooded the streets in the country’s capital and its second-largest city again Sunday morning.

President Trump offered support for the protesters, [See Iran, A3]

State prisons face new breed of violent gangs

By MATTHEW ORMSETH

Maurice Vasquez dances in his prison cell to blaring rap music, wearing a straw hat and designer glasses.

“Only motherf— in here with these \$1,200 Cartier frames,” Vasquez says in a video filmed on a contraband cellphone. In other clips, he displays a thick gold chain — “Tiffany and Company,” he claims — and drinks prison-distilled liquor.

Vasquez isn’t the first California prisoner to enjoy forbidden luxuries. The Mexican Mafia, Aryan Brotherhood and other gangs have long trafficked drugs, al-

cohol and, in more recent years, phones, which enable inmates to carry out shake-downs, gambling rackets and killings on the streets of L.A. County.

But Vasquez is a new breed, law enforcement officials say, one whose organization has thrived in a system intended to protect vulnerable inmates. His group, the Riders, is largely composed of men who have renounced membership in other gangs.

California houses tens of thousands of inmates in protective housing. Some are [See Gangs, A6]



MARK BOSTER Los Angeles Times

ITS MIRRORS properly angled, a tower glows hot at Ivanpah solar plant in 2014.

Keeping outdated solar tech

Site is costly and kills birds, but state needs energy

By HAYLEY SMITH

The electricity it makes is expensive, its technology has been superseded, and it’s incinerating thousands of birds mid-flight each year. The Trump administration wants to see this unusual power plant closed, and in a rare instance of alignment,

the Biden administration did, too.

But the state of California is insisting the Ivanpah power plant in the Mojave Desert stay open for at least 13 more years. It’s an indication of just how much electricity artificial intelligence and data centers are demanding.

Ivanpah’s owners, which

include NRG Energy, Google and BrightSource, had agreed with their main customer, Pacific Gas & Electric, to end their contract and largely close Ivanpah. But last month, the California Public Utilities Commission unanimously rejected that agreement, citing concerns about reliability [See Ivanpah, A10]

In Altadena, rage and a call for state probe

Residents demand accountability for 19 deaths and epic losses in Black enclave.

By GRACE TOOHEY

The “Rising Together” float in Pasadena’s Rose Parade was supposed to celebrate the resiliency of Los Angeles County in the face of the unprecedented double disaster that flattened thousands of homes and took 31 lives last January.

But amid the float’s proud phoenix and colorful California poppies, two frustrated fire survivors unfurled a surprise message: “AG Bonta, Altadena demands an investigation.”

A parade worker quickly pulled down the sign, but the statement made its mark, cutting through conversations about recovery and progress with the gnawing questions that continue to haunt so many Eaton fire survivors:

Why were timely evacuation alerts not issued for west Altadena, which accounted for almost all of the Eaton fire deaths and experienced the most widespread devastation? Why were there almost

no fire trucks in west Altadena, known to be a historically Black, less affluent section of the unincorporated town?

And why have repeated probes resulted in almost no answers? No accountability?

“It is shameful that we have not yet seen any kind of serious undertaking of righting the wrongs that were committed in this fire,” said Gina Clayton-Johnson, a lifelong Altadenan who helped unfurl the sign on the Rose Parade float. “We have a responsibility to not let this kind of thing happen again.”

That feeling was only amplified as the community marked one year since the deadly blaze.

At a recent memorial gathering, Clayton-Johnson urged her former — and, hopefully, future — neighbors to join the growing coalition calling on California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta to launch a full, independent investigation into the response to the fire that devastated their community, killing 19 and destroying more than 9,000 structures.

“As a person who wants to return to this community but not be stupid to return... I want answers,” Clayton-Johnson said. [See West Altadena, A9]

QUIET PAIN: As many focus on rebuilding, a man reflects on the loss of his sister. CALIFORNIA, B1

Law let politician avoid jail for child abuse accusations

California legislators decry mental health diversion granted to ex-Kern supervisor.

By MELISSA GOMEZ

A mental health diversion granted to a former Kern County politician is coming under fire from numerous California lawmakers and child welfare advocates, who say a repeatedly amended state law is allowing an accused child abuser to avoid prosecution and possible jail time.

Zack Scrivner, a former Kern County supervisor, was charged with felony child abuse in February after he was accused of inappropriately touching one of his children in 2024. But because of a Dec. 19 ruling by a judge, he will avoid a trial and instead be funneled into a mental health diversion program — an initiative aimed at helping defendants with mental health disorders get treatment instead of imprisonment for certain crimes.

While supporters say mental health diversions

help certain defendants get needed mental health treatment, lawmakers in both parties have blasted the Scrivner decision and the legislative changes that led to it. Assemblymember Dr. Jasmeet Bains (D-Delano) issued a scathing statement, describing the ruling as an “Epstein loophole,” a reference to convicted child sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

“I specialize in family and addiction medicine, so I know the value of mental health diversion. ... It was designed to help people get treatment and rehabilitation in appropriate cases, not to provide an escape hatch to sexually assault children,” she said. “This Epstein loophole needs to be closed.”

At the end of their 2018 legislative session, California lawmakers approved a number of legal reforms, many aimed at keeping homeless people out of jail. One of these altered which defendants could qualify for mental health diversions. The change specifically excluded people accused of crimes such as murder, rape and child sex crime but did not exclude those accused of [See Scrivner, A7]

Battle over supportive housing erupts in affluent Santa Monica

By GAVIN J. QUINTON

It was a scene that left residents of this pricey, palm-lined Santa Monica neighborhood flabbergasted.

Without warning, some 50 strangers had suddenly arrived in vans and were occupying a vacant building on Ocean Avenue the night before Thanksgiving.

Some of them smoked cigarettes, others had dogs running around unleashed, and at least one fight broke out during the boisterous move-in.

“If I didn’t know what was going on, I would have thought it was theater,” resident Ashley Oelsen recalled.

But Oelsen and her neighbors would soon learn that these new arrivals were clients of an unannounced and unpermitted sober living operation — a revelation that has triggered outrage among residents and once again pitted Santa Monica officials against a controversial Los Angeles developer.

The dustup over the sober living center is just the latest in a series of clashes between city officials and Leo Pustilnikov, a developer

who was recently ousted from the Downtown Santa Monica Board of Directors for “not being a helpful contributor.” The episode has also focused harsh light on a proposal by Pustilnikov and others to convert two senior living facilities into luxury housing.

The empty, low-rise buildings at 413 and 825 Ocean Ave. sit on prime, blufftop real estate overlooking Palisades Park and the Pacific Ocean. While the properties have been zoned for use as supportive housing for years, they are sur- [See Santa Monica, A9]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

GOLDEN GLOBES



Leonardo DiCaprio was up for an acting award, one of nine nominations for Paul Thomas Anderson’s film “One Battle After Another.” Scan this code to read our coverage at latimes.com.

Rams’ Stafford steals more souls

“Let’s go snatch these guys’ hearts,” he said before game-winning drive at Carolina. Next up: Chicago. **SPORTS, D1**

Candidates try to break from pack

Immigration, homelessness and affordability at forefront in governor’s race. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 76/52. **B6**

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